

The five mosaics are magical, and serve as scrying mirrors. When a creature attuned to the Six-Face Throne is in this room, they can use a bonus action to cause the mosaics to display a pixelated image of the world outside the cube. The five mosaics show a color panoramic view of the exterior of the cube as seen from faces 2 to 5. Creatures and objects upon those faces appear as if they were semi-transparent, allowing an attuned creature to see creatures walking on the cube while also seeing through them to the landscape beyond. The only direction that cannot be seen is the bottom of the cube (face 1).

The scrying has no visible effect on the exterior of the cube, and creatures on faces 2 to 5 have no idea they are being scried on. The scrying effect ends when the creature that activated it leaves area 6.28. The scrying doesn't show any of the interior rooms or tunnels of the cube.

When a creature attuned to the Six-Face Throne is not in this area, it can use a bonus action to send its consciousness into the mosaic and see into the control room. The creature's head appears in color in one of the five mosaics, and it can see from that mosaic's perspective while not losing any awareness of its own surroundings. The creature can also hear whatever is happening in the room, and can speak to creatures in the room in a supernaturally loud, booming voice. If multiple creatures attuned to the Six-Face Throne attempt this at the same time, their heads appear in separate mosaics.

Cannon Controls. This elaborate apparatus of buttons, switches and levers can be reached from one of the six chairs of the Six-Face Throne. Pipes run into the wall from the apparatus, pushing past other pipes and pistons before reaching area 6.28A. Metal tubes from the Heart Engine also converge on the opening. A successful DC 20 Intelligence (Arcana or History) check identifies the cannon controls as belonging to some kind of magical siege engine.

The entrance leading to area 6.28A initially appears to be jammed shut with pixelated pipes and cables. A Small creature can sneak through to area 6.28A with a successful DC 25 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check.

The cannon is nonfunctional until five faces of the Six-Face Throne are activated (see the "Awakening the Cube" sidebar).

AREA 6.28A. CANNON SHAFT

This round, pixelated metal shaft leads some 250 feet toward face 5, gradually widening from 2 feet in diameter to 20 feet at area 5.5. The walls of the shaft are warm and hum with energy. Tiny maintenance shafts, grates, and pipes along the way vent heat and occasional harmless electrical discharges.

As it reaches area 5.5, the shaft ends at an interior door (see that area's description). Anyone approaching the door from area 6.28 becomes aware of an increasing stench of decay and rotten meat.

If the cannon is fired, the interior and exterior doors at area 5.5 open and a violet light begins to build in intensity at the bottom of the shaft. Any creatures in area 6.28A or area 5.5 are killed the next round as

the cannon shaft is flooded with enough energy to destroy a castle.

AREA 6.29: LIBRARY

This room of black onyx pillars and arches is not pixelated, thanks to a constant spray of Styx water (see the "Styx Mist" sidebar).

The library is lined with stone shelves, making it one of the few rooms in the cube not entirely made of metal. Glowing wall panels provide dim light, and three *driftglobes* provide additional illumination as they float through the stacks. Several stone tables and chairs provide places to sit and read.

The shelves are covered with books and scrolls—many suffering damage from the dripping mist. The majority of the scrolls are in Infernal, with others in Common, Dwarvish, or rare and forgotten languages of the Material Plane. Most of the books are of six types:

- Histories of the great military battles of forgotten empires
- Descriptions of armor and weapons
- Lists of names of the dead
- Tedious legal texts describing the many laws of Acheron and the gruesome punishments for breaking them
- Transcribed court proceedings from legal cases in Acheron, including the gruesome punishments decreed by infernal judges
- Hymns to Bane, god of tyrants

Several stacks of books have been pulled from the shelves by the skull lord, and now rest in puddles on the tables. Among them are four reference books on multiple-headed creatures, from the hydra to the chimera to the ettin. There are also eight tomes on mechanical and electrical engineering, two books discussing the River Styx and its effects, five books on brain surgery, and four books on the history of Faerûn's Sword Coast. These last titles were written centuries ago and are completely outdated.

One cabinet between the main doors contains ink, quill pens, blank paper, and writing implements, and has two shelves stacked with games. A character who searches the game shelf finds dice, several damp decks of cards (including Three Dragon Ante), a fine chess set (120 gp), a fine backgammon set (180 gp), a checkers-like game played with small opals (worth 1,000 gp), and several more-obscure games. The skull lord might use games to test the intelligence of the characters (see "The Skull Lord's Plan").

Any character who can read Infernal and who spends 1 hour searching the library for interesting books discovers four *spell scrolls* tucked away in the stacks—*creation*, *detect thoughts*, *fly*, and *Otiluke's resilient sphere*.

If a character specifically searches the library for secret doors, a successful DC 25 Wisdom (Perception) check discovers a sliding bookshelf that leads to area 6.30.

AREA 6.30: SECRET LIBRARY

This dimly lit room contains the library's most precious books. All have been pixelated, as even the skull lord

isn't aware of this place. (Avnas is now the only person who knows about it.)

While the characters initially explore this room, they begin to hear strange whispers coming from all around them. If they do not leave immediately, 1d4 + 1 **allips** emerge from the walls and attack, formed out of the evil lore of this vile place. (See *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for information on the allip.)

If the books in this area are viewed unpixelated, most are revealed as bizarre poetry, secret plans for military battles in Acheron, or fiendish spellbooks. (You can determine the contents of these books if any wizard characters are interested in them.) An especially large stack of books offers up all the gory details of the tortures inflicted on prisoners of war and disobedient soldiers in the laboratory at area 6.23 and the torture chamber at area 6.43.

Two particularly old and heavy books are set on two pedestals at the center of the room. One is a *tome of clear thought*. The other is the *book of patterns* (see the "New Magic Items" appendix).

AREA 6.31: VARGO'S CHAMBER

If it has not been encountered already, Vargo the **skull lord**^M is 50 percent likely to be in this room when the characters enter. Vargo is always accompanied by its bodyguards—a pixelated **merregon**^M and a pixelated **shadar-kai shadow dancer**^M—that defend their lord to the death. But the skull lord's shadar-kai servant is someone the characters might be looking for (see "The Missing Shadar-kai," below).

The steel door to this room is unpixelated, and is inscribed with a carving of three skulls. The door opens only to a key the skull lord wears around its neck, but it can be picked with a successful DC 30 Dexterity check using thieves' tools, or it can be broken down. The door has AC 18, 30 hit points, a damage threshold of 5, immunity to psychic and poison damage, and resistance to cold and fire damage.

Beyond the door is a sumptuous room which is not pixelated, thanks to a constant spray of Styx water (see the "Styx Mist" sidebar). This area is noticeably colder than the corridor outside. The room is lit by a combination of ghostly glowing worms that crawl out of the furniture, a dusty candelabra with candles made of eyeballs glued together, and red glowing panels in the walls.

The walls here are lined with black curtains. In the center of the room is a large black steel sarcophagus lined with red velvet. The rest of the room is divided into three parts, each featuring the same furniture: plush high-backed chairs, kingly tables, and fine cabinets and wardrobes. However, all these fine furnishings have been so damaged by the damp as to be worthless.

The three tables are each set with three silver cups (a total of nine cups, 75 gp each). Each of the three sections of the room also has a wine rack loaded with twenty bottles of rich wine (sixty bottles, 90 gp each). In a wineskin hidden among one of the sets of bottles is six doses of torpor poison (see chapter 8 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*). It can be found with a successful DC

15 Wisdom (Perception) check, or by any character who takes all the bottles.

At the bottom of the sarcophagus, visible to any character who searches the steel coffin, is a musty *spell scroll of dimension door*.

One of the three sections of the room contains a glass case with the partially pixelated rotting head of a hideous devilish creature—the dead Earl Andromalius.

Best Two out of Three. When the characters first enter Cube 1717, only two of Vargo's three heads are fully active and aware. The third head babbles and chatters idiotically, when not sucking from a straw attached to a flask tied around its neck. Each of the skull lords' other two heads has a key tied around its neck—to the treasury (area 6.26) and this area. The flask the third head drinks from is filled with Styx water, keeping the skull lord safe from the pixelating curse.

Vargo was once three evil adventurers who teamed up to defeat the devil Earl Andromalius. When they were defeated, Andromalius subjected them to a horrific curse, combining the three of them into a single undead being. At first, the three heads hated being bound together, but over hundreds of years in Andromalius's prison, they gradually developed something like a group mind. When the cube was overtaken by the pixelating curse, Vargo managed to remain uninfected and gain its freedom.

Vargo's unique ability to deal with the curse stems from the skull lord's unique makeup. The Styx water absorbed by Vargo's undead body is strong enough to protect the skull lord from pixelating, but only the head that actually drinks the water is subject to its mental effects. With two heads still functioning, Vargo has survived the chaos with its wits intact, and was able to develop the Six-Face Throne as a way to control creatures pixelated by the curse. Vargo's two conscious heads became the Throne's two initial controllers. Sladek the pixelated mage became the third.

Fighting the Skull Lord. With only two heads active, Vargo is slightly weaker than normal. It has the statistics of a **skull lord**^M with these changes:

- It cannot cast 7th-level spells.
- It has only two legendary actions.

Vargo has also claimed the *Ioun stones* once owned by the wizard Sladek, which grant it additional features:

- It cannot be surprised.
- Its Intelligence is 18.
- Its Wisdom is 17.
- Its proficiency bonus is increased by 1.
- It has a +1 bonus to AC.
- It can cast *fear* once without expending a spell slot.

See "Ioun Stones" earlier in the adventure and chapter 7 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide* for more information on Vargo's *Ioun stones*.

Vargo is a cunning, charismatic opponent who commands the absolute obedience of all the pixelated creatures on the cube. If the characters attack the skull lord, it musters all available pixelated creatures to its defense. But if possible, it tries to parley with the characters in the hope of them letting down their

guard. The skull lord tries to gauge the intelligence of each of the characters, and keeps a special eye out for wizards. See “The Skull Lord’s Plan” earlier in the adventure for more information about Vargo’s tactics and endgame.

The Missing Shadar-kai. Though Astilbe in her pixelated form looks very much like any of the other humanoid pixelated guards, characters can note her shadowy coloration and the spiked chain she wields in combat. If Fern is present, she recognizes her friend at once, calling out and pleading with her to surrender. This takes Astilbe out of the fight. If Astilbe is unpixelated at any point, she regains her original alignment and statistics, and both she and Fern fight alongside the characters.

As a pixelated **shadar-kai shadow dancer**^M, Astilbe has the following changes:

- Her alignment is lawful neutral.
- She has telepathy out to a range of 120 feet, but can use it to communicate only with other pixelated creatures.
- She is immune to the frightened condition.
- She has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide while in a pixelated area.

AREA 6.32: BROKEN AREA

As the characters approach this area, they hear a scream that rises and quickly falls. If they wait in the hall, the pattern of sound repeats every six seconds. When the characters can see into this area, they observe that every six seconds, a naked humanoid appears from above them and plummets down into the darkness below. See area 6.14 for more information.

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. The walls, ceiling and floor are smashed open here, forming a great tear through which pixelated pipes and gigantic steel girders are visible.

Unpixelated. The shattered girders, pipes, and floor reveal the deadly sharpness of their edges.

Climbing the Girders. Navigating the mangled girders and pipes is difficult and dangerous. Climbing the 200 feet between this area and area 6.14 or area 6.39 requires four successful DC 17 Strength (Athletics) checks (one for each 50 feet climbed). On a failed check, a character slips and falls, plummeting to area 6.39 and taking 1d6 bludgeoning damage for each 10 feet fallen (maximum 20d6). A character who sees the area as pixelated has disadvantage on the check.

NEARING THE END

The lowest level beneath face 6 is darker and dingier than the two levels above. The rumbling of the cube’s engines is loud in all areas here, and the pixelated walls are marred by rust-colored stains.

The temples and side rooms on this level are filthy with cubic debris—ash, broken metal, mud and dirt—and the decomposing pixelated bodies of soldiers. Only the wide main hallway that runs around the outside of the lower level is relatively clear of bodies and rubble, as it is swept clean by the hellfire engine (see area 6.41).

With each successful check, a character still takes 7 (2d6) slashing damage from the jagged metal along the descent path.

AREA 6.33: EMPTY GUARDROOMS

These rooms are identical to area 6.8, but no guards are present here unless you wish to increase the ranks of the skull lord’s followers.

AREA 6.33A. GRAVITY JUNCTION/ GUARDROOM

This room is identical to area 6.8, except it features no guards and has two passages that lead to interior doors, then to area 4.2 and area 5.3 beyond.

AREA 6.34: DAMAGED CORRIDOR

A great explosion has collapsed this corridor, melting and breaking its steel walls and the girders behind them. The walls are blackened and discolored. Everything is pixelated, and great heaps of metal cubes fill the collapsed area.

Like a living body, the cube is slowly regenerating this area. If the characters rest here or try to remove the rubble, they see that the rubble is gradually clearing itself, oozing back into the walls in great cubical clots. It takes three days from when the characters first enter the cube for a corridor to completely repair itself.

In places, the pixelated pipes and tubes behind the walls are exposed and smashed to reveal a black pixelated liquid dripping out—something uncomfortably similar to both oil and blood. Any character who presses their ear to the wall can hear the engines in the cube pulsing in a steady rhythm—matching the beating of the Archquadrone’s heart.

AREA 6.35: STYX PUDDLES

The rigid right angles and cubic forms of this level are interrupted in areas where the metal walls are bent and broken. In the center of each of these twisted areas is a pool of murky black Styx water, 1 to 3 feet deep. When the cube first fell to the Material Plane, numerous sections were still flooded with Styx water. As the cube regenerated, most of that water was pumped out through area 6.47, but these last few pools remain.

Pixelated creatures do not pursue characters into the pools. A character who wades through the Styx water feels a chill as their memories begin to fade, but is at no risk of suffering the water’s mental effects. A creature immersed in the water must succeed on a DC 15 Intelligence saving throw or lose their memories (see “The Styx Sea”). Creatures suffering the pixelating curse aren’t cured by exposure to the water unless they fully immerse themselves.

AREA 6.36: ANTECHAMBER OF THE GREAT TEMPLE OF TIAMAT.

This area is dark, except for a red flickering light shining from area 6.38. The features of the area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. This tall-ceilinged room is decorated with huge pixelated relief carvings in red and black stone, showing creatures with wings. Eight oubliettes around